



the world, guys seem to be playing 50-plus T20 games a year.

This part of the world is a tough place to play, but I don't think it gets any better than the IPL. It's a tournament everyone wants to be a part of.

You're playing against the best players in the world, and we all know the crowds, the passion, and the following that cricket gets here. So yeah, there are a lot of positives to the format.

If you could shed some light on your preparation process ahead of the IPL or any other major international event?

I think the positive of playing so much T20 cricket is that, generally, you are up to speed [with trends], having moved around different franchises and tournaments around the world.

Yeah, it's a format that you think is only four overs for a bowler.

Speaking from experience, I think you need to do the work and make sure you are conditioned to be able to play three or so T20 games in a week. And you are adding the challenges of travel, diet, sleep, climate — things that come into effect while touring the subcontinent. It's a combination of things that you need to get right.

Then again, you're playing the best players in the world in a competition like the IPL. So it's a great challenge, but something that I've embraced.

I've moved away from potential cricket and my career as such with the New Zealand cricket team, but I still definitely have ambitions to represent my country.

[Moving away from the contract] was basically to get a good opportunity to see more of the world, play a little less cricket, and see my family a whole lot more. So yeah, no regrets from my end.

Impactful call: Trent Boult on Impact Player rule - "It has allowed teams to equip batters that can bat down to No. 10. It shows in the scores." R. V. MOORTHY

As a fast bowler, what are your thoughts on the Impact Player rule in the IPL? The house seems to be divided...

It has made a huge difference. It has allowed teams to equip batters who can bat down to No. 10. It shows in the scores. The boundary count is higher than it has ever been; we have already seen a couple of 250-plus scores.

When it comes to analysing data from a bowling point of view and looking at how the guys get out and where they were hit for sixes, I think it's skewed massively. Because there's data that has been there for years with the standard 11 players; now you can slightly manipulate that with the balance of the sides.

I'm sure it's what everyone wants to see. They want to see high-scoring games. They want to see record chases, and I think that's what we're going to see more often.

And what are your thoughts on the newly introduced two bouncers per over rule?

It's a good initiative. The grounds are pretty small. The balls aren't moving around as much as they have in previous times. It just gives the bowlers another card up their sleeve to try to be that little bit more unpredictable. So I'm sure it will have a good effect throughout the tournament.

Many believe that Shane Bond joining the Royals as the bowling coach has helped the fast bowlers immensely. You have had a long association with him — in the New Zealand team and later Mumbai Indians. What does he bring to the table?

I have had a relationship with for probably a dozen years, and he's great. As a player, he's very experienced; he was a very skilled bowler. One of the best things he brings to the table is his level-headedness. He is very calm,